> may be carrying on their insidious exploitation through mixed or even purely Indian bureaucratic apparatus. All these things make no difference.[9]

For this reason, ‘what we wanted to point out was that according to the verdict of your court we had waged war and we are therefore war prisoners. And we claim to be treated as such, i.e. we claim to be shot dead instead of being hanged. It rests with you to prove that you really meant what your court has said’.[10] It was a dying last wish not to be fulfilled. So relentless was the Raj’s persecution of these men, so determined the state to remove all trace of their knowledge and existence, that death for them would be designed to be deliberately ignominious. The authorities were not going to grant the three the dignity of being shot as political prisoners. They were to be hanged and even that before their time. And yet, even in their hanging, Bhagat Singh, Sukhdev and Rajguru managed to cock a snook at the British Raj. They refused to be cowed. All three walked out of their cells smiling. They mounted the scaffold with alacrity, refused to have their faces masked, hugged each other warmly and grasped the rope themselves and put it around their necks. They knew how to die after all. And they died in the manner of their choosing with their heads unbowed. They died the death of a revolutionary, of an *Inqalabi*!